“belts” and its maritime “roads.” This would grow China’s influence in regions to India’s west, joining even more vigorous Chinese activities in the Bay of Bengal region to India’s east, as depicted by Muni in this volume. The PLA-Navy will find a new, powerful, and frequently like-minded partner in the Gulf and Arabian Sea. Stated very simply and directly, the new China–Iran strategic partnership constituted another and significant element in China’s protracted Go-like game of creeping encirclement of India.[1] India responded to China’s push for expanded partnership with Iran by itself seeking deeper understanding and cooperation with Iran. India’s need to counter Beijing’s courtship of Tehran raises questions for India’s relations with the United States and for India’s practice of strategic autonomy.

China–Indian rivalry toward Iran is curiously asymmetrical. As this chapter will show, China views its relationship with Iran as part of an intense rivalry but deems China’s rivals to be Europe in the economic sphere and the United States in the strategic area. Competition with India does not seem to figure much into China’s Iran policy; China perhaps simply does not view India as a serious rival. For India, however, the prospect of Iranian cooperation in facilitating the growth of Chinese influence in the Gulf region has become discernibly important over the past several years.

Recession of US pressure on Iran and the intensification of India–China rivalry

The US-led drive to lift international sanctions on Tehran that culminated in agreement on the JCPOA in July 2015 changed Beijing’s and New Delhi’s balancing between Washington and Tehran. The JCPOA created a more permissive